

The machine leaves the room

Jumpstart 2026 · Day 2 field guide

The black box

14 min · in fours

Your table has a box with a rule inside it. You may ask it **eight** questions. You give it a whole number from 0 to 99; it gives you back a number.

Write your prediction down before you ask. A question whose answer you already knew teaches you nothing, and a question you did not predict teaches you almost nothing. This is the whole discipline.

#	WE SEND	WE PREDICT IT RETURNS	IT ACTUALLY RETURNED
1			
2			
3			
4			
5			
6			
7			
8			

Our rule is:

How confident are you? not at all 1 2 3 4 5 certain — and what would change your mind?

AFTER THE REVEAL

The input that told the two boxes apart: _____

Would we have found it? Honestly: _____

Every test we ran passed. What does that entitle us to say about the box?

Two machines that left the room

20 min

Ariane 5, 1996

Therac-25, 1985–87

The software had never failed. What made it wrong this time?

There was no villain. So where was the fault?

Everyone who should have caught it. List them. Then cross out anyone who did not know enough to catch it.

Who is left? _____

Auditing a machine that sounds certain

The model's answer

12 min · in fours

Your table has a printed answer to a question about a 16-bit adder. It is well written, it is confident, and it contains exactly one error.

1. The error is:

2. What did *you* need to already know to catch it?

3. What would the *model* have needed to know?

4. Could you have caught this by reading the answer more carefully? Or did it take something else?

Yesterday the room had 20 gates in it and settled in 8 beats. Twenty is not eight. If you kept hold of why, one of these two errors was already visible to you.

Where the interlocks are

13 min

The Therac-25 lost its hardware interlock because the software was trusted. For the next four years, your interlocks are people.

One person or place I will actually go to when I am stuck:

What I will say when I get there — in actual words:

Two lines

keep this one

One thing I will build a mental model of before I trust it:

One person I will ask, sooner than I want to:

You still have the wire. In four years someone will offer you a ring. Neither one can be issued to a model.